Editing: Patterns & Rhythm

Functions of Editing: Space (Spatial Relationships Between Shots)

One of the most powerful effects of film editing is to create a sense of space in the mind of the viewer. When we are watching any single shot from a film, our sense of the overall space of the scene is necessarily limited by the height, width, and depth of the film frame during that shot. But as other shots are placed in close proximity to that original shot, our sense of the overall space in which the characters are moving shifts and expands. The juxtaposition of shots within a scene can cause us to have a fairly complex sense of that overall space (something like a mental map) even if no single shot discloses more than a fraction of that space to us at a time.

The power of editing to establish spatial relationships between shots is so strong, in fact, that filmmakers have almost no need to ensure that a real space exists whose dimensions correspond to the one implied by editing. Countless films, especially historical dramas and science-fiction films, rely heavily on the power of editing to fool us into perceiving their worlds as vast and complete even as we are shown only tiny fractions of the implied space.

In 1977, George Lucas used a series of small sets to create the illusion of the massive Millennium Falcon in the original *Star Wars*. Six films later, in J. J. Abrams's *Star Wars: The Force Awakens* (2015), editing helps represent the interior space of a freighter huge enough to swallow the Millennium Falcon whole. Combining footage shot on two relatively modest sets—the intersection of two long corridors and a small crawl space—editors Maryann Brandon and Mary Jo Markey use fragmentation, juxtaposition, crosscutting, and screen direction to create the impression of a large labyrinth of passageways during a chaotic chase scene involving the ragtag protagonists, a couple of ruthless death gangs, and a trio of ravenous space monsters.

***Star Wars: The Force Awakens* (J. J. Abrams, 2015)**

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In addition to painting a mental picture of the space of a scene, editing manipulates our sense of spatial relationships among characters, objects, and their surroundings. To communicate spatial relationships, editors rely on the juxtaposition of shots to convey meaning not contained in any single shot by itself—further evidence that the tendency of viewers to interpret shots in relation to surrounding shots is the most fundamental assumption behind all film editing.